Yaakov Built Booths for His Flock: The Guest of the Third Day and the First Sukkot in the Torah

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On the night of Sunday, 27 September 2026, the third of the seven guests entered the sukkah. In the order of the Zohar, Avraham came first, on Shabbat night in 5787 (Friday, 25 September 2026), Yitzchak on the second night, and on the third night Yaakov. On the fourth night, Monday, 28 September 2026, Moshe comes, and David will close the week on Hoshana Rabbah.

Of all the guests, Yaakov has the oldest claim on the word *sukkah*. The first sukkot in the Torah are his.

A house for himself, booths for the cattle

After the long night at the Yabbok, after the wrestling and the new name, after meeting Esav and parting from him in peace, Yaakov stops. "And Yaakov journeyed to Sukkot, and built himself a house, and for his cattle he made sukkot; therefore he called the name of the place Sukkot" (Bereishit 33:17).

Read the verse slowly. Yaakov builds two things. For himself, a house. For the animals in his care, booths. And when he names the place, he does not name it for the house. He names it for the booths.

It is a small detail, and the Torah rarely wastes one. The house was for Yaakov. The booths were for those who depended on him and could not build for themselves. The place remembers the second kind of building.

The man of the tents

Yaakov is introduced as "a simple man, dwelling in tents" (Bereishit 25:27). He is not the hunter in the field. He is the one who stays, who tends, who lives close to what he is responsible for. Twenty years with Lavan taught him the cost of that tending: "By day the heat consumed me, and the frost by night, and sleep fled from my eyes" (Bereishit 31:40). He knew what it meant to guard a flock that belonged, in the end, to someone else.

So when he finally has a flock of his own and a place to stop, the first thing the Torah records is shelter for them.

What the Torah asks of our booths

The festival of Sukkot carries Yaakov's word, but the Torah gives it a wider circle. "You shall rejoice in your festival, you and your son and your daughter, your servant and your maidservant, the Levite, the stranger, the orphan and the widow who are within your gates" (Devarim 16:14). The sukkah is not only a private hut for a private joy. It is measured by who is sheltered in it.

That is Yaakov's lesson, carried from Bereishit into the command of the chag. Build your house; there is nothing wrong with a house. But the name of the place, the thing that is remembered, is the shelter you made for those who depend on you.

On Chol HaMoed this is practical. Who has not yet been invited? Which neighbor, which widower, which new family in the building, which soldier home for a day, has no sukkah of their own this Sukkot? The ushpizin of the Zohar come every night whether we call them or not. The guests of Devarim 16 come only if someone opens the door.

Yaakov's quiet strength

We sometimes picture strength as the hunter's strength: reach, conquest, force. Yaakov's strength is different. He limps from the Yabbok. He never becomes a man of the field. Yet he is the father whose name the whole people carries, *Bnei Yisrael*, the children of the one who wrestled and endured.

His strength is the strength of the one who stops to build shelter. It is the strength of a people that, after every journey and every wrestling, builds booths and sits in them with its children and its guests, and calls the place by what it gave rather than by what it kept.

On the fourth night Moshe enters. Before he does, let Yaakov's verse sit on the table: a house for himself, booths for those in his care, and a place named for the booths.

For the table

1. The first sukkot in the Torah were built by Yaakov, for his animals.
2. He built a house for himself too, but the place was named for the booths.
3. Our sukkah is also measured by who we bring into it.

Sources

- Bereishit 33:17 (Yaakov builds a house and makes sukkot for his cattle)
- Bereishit 25:27 ("a simple man, dwelling in tents")
- Bereishit 31:40 (Yaakov's years of tending the flock)
- Devarim 16:14 (rejoicing with the dependent, the stranger, the orphan and the widow)
- Zohar, Emor 103a–104a (the *ushpizin*)

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